



NFL In-Season Product Available NOW! [SUBSCRIBE >>](#)

Thorman's Snaps and Pace: Week 1

PAT THORMAN // SEP 9, 2026



*Polymarket Sign-Up Bonus: Deposit \$10,
get \$50!*

Trade on NFL games every week on Polymarket. [Sign up for Polymarket](#) with code ETR for a \$50 bonus when you deposit \$10.

[Sign Up Now](#)

[Up In Pace](#) | [Slow-Paced Slogs](#) | [No-Huddle Notes](#)

Welcome to the Week 1 edition of *Snaps & Pace* — back-to-back winner of the FSWA's Best Football Series — where we examine trends in play volume and game pace. It is meant to be a 30,000-foot view of upcoming contests, while identifying main-slate matchups that will — and will not — be played on fertile fantasy soil. For a primer on why this is important, [click here](#).

It is always advisable to know what you don't know, but it's especially true for Week 1 of an NFL season. Not often are we surrounded by so many confidently wrong opinions. The tricky part, clearly, is identifying them before they correct.

From a pace perspective, there are always factors to be assured of. We're pretty damn sure the **Kellen Moore** Saints and **Dak Prescott** Cowboys will again play fast. The Bengals are going to pass and, for as long as possible, the Dolphins will run — and **Aaron Rodgers** is going to run his mouth until play clocks kiss zero at the snap.

Week 1 is the perfect opportunity to challenge our assumptions and zig while others zag. We have collectively constructed six months' worth of priors and, until proven plainly wrong on the field, they'll get ridden harder than trailer-park **Jed York**. If we aren't especially sure of a projection, it's at least worth considering it's wrong.

We are back, finally. There's no better time of year to lean into what's

known, question widely held assumptions, and finish up with a gaggle of questions that Week 1 will begin answering. It's been an interminable offseason — so let's dive in.

“Situation neutral” is meant to provide context and refers to plays while the game is within seven points during the first three quarters (minus the final two minutes of the first half). Neutral Pace (average play-clock seconds used), Neutral Pace Over Expected (POE), and Pass Rate Over Expected (PROE) are based on neutral game script and are provided by our data science team.

Up In Pace

Green Bay Packers at Minnesota Vikings

Projected for only the fifth-most points on the main slate, this divisional matchup features a traditionally slow offense and one that uncharacteristically crawled, and poorly, last season. Green Bay has finished dead last in neutral seconds per snap more often during HC **Matt LaFleur**'s seven-year tenure (three times) than above 25th (once). Their games almost always lack volume, and the Packers have consistently skewed run-heavy. That should change, especially with hammer back **Josh Jacobs** on the Commissioner's Exempt List, a currently suspect defense, and a finally condensed wide receiver rotation. The working theory is that looser game scripts, more throwing, and fewer time-sucking substitutions will increase offensive pace. Sounds great on paper, anyway.

The Vikings enter 2026 from the opposite direction, having traditionally been a fast offense. That is, until last year and **J.J. McCarthy** happened. Minnesota dropped from 11th in neutral seconds per snap to 21st. Their

PROE dipped from third highest (+3.5%) to 14th (-1.2%), and the no-huddle rate fell from ninth to 21st. Vikings games went from averaging the sixth-most combined snaps to the 31st. Their defense took steps forward and, with the offense cratering, Minnesota's contests yielded the third-fewest combined points (39.8). That defense should be formidable again, but it's been a boom-or-bust blitz-heavy unit under **Brian Flores**. In the right back-and-forth game environment — especially played indoors — that volatility can help spawn fantasy-friendly chaos. In this first NFC North meeting, with **Kevin O'Connell** sending McCarthy to the glue factory in favor of **Kyler Murray**, there's a strong chance that's exactly what we get.

New Orleans Saints at Detroit Lions

We would be remiss not mentioning the fastest-paced matchup of the week, even if its 50-point total is about as subtle as **Dan Campbell**. When leaning into what we know, this is our rock. There has been talk of the Saints skewing more toward the run than last year, when they were eighth in neutral pass rate (59%). That may be their intention, but as touchdown road dogs, **Kellen Moore** will eventually need to dial up plenty of passes to go with his preferred blazing tempo. A thin running back room behind **Travis Etienne** won't help potential plans to pound the rock. New Orleans lapped the league in every conceivable pace measure a year ago, and Saints games were third in combined offensive plays. Any matchup they're involved in is a strong bet to be voluminous.

Any matchup in Detroit's dome comes with a similarly strong forecast for fireworks. Lions games were top 10 in combined snaps, seventh in explosive play rate, and averaged the third-most total points (52.6). Detroit's suspect secondary is already banged up, while its defensive front is essentially an **Aidan Hutchinson** solo act, pending **Alim McNeill** getting back up to speed. While the Lions haven't played consistently fast, they did finish eighth in neutral pace last year and sped up as the season progressed. They also threw more after Campbell regained play-calling duties. We will

surely get plenty of **Jahmyr Gibbs**, but the void behind him on the depth chart could nudge the Lions toward the air. The Saints need little help creating a pulsing pace, but they'll get some anyway.

Chicago Bears at Carolina Panthers

It would be easy to tack the Bucs-Bengals matchup here. Both offenses historically spawn voluminous contests via aggressive pass rates, if not by moving quickly between plays. Also, the total is over 50 points, and Ray Charles can see that fantasy goodness. The Bears might try to score 50 every week on their own, judging by **Ben Johnson's** soundbites. Either way, they'll likely move fast. Chicago ranked fifth in neutral pace over the final month, plus the playoffs — speeding up from 18th before that. The Bears' PROE leapt from 25th to 10th. Their games ranked sixth in both total points and combined plays. Opponents operated with the fourth-fastest neutral pace against Chicago last year. With a swinging-door defense that projects to give it up like spring-break freshmen, the fantasy environments will be pure sex.

The Panthers might be one of those aforementioned assumptions worth challenging. We have been rug-pulled before on their tempo, with hollow words from **Dave Canales** and **Brad Idzik** yielding a plodding pace for their impotent offense. So why is this time different? Perhaps it isn't, but **Bryce Young** talked about his "greater mastery of the offense" allowing him to break the huddle faster. Canales said the focus is on line-of-scrimmage adjustments and "being able to play with tempo a little bit more." Idzik stressed being "urgent to the line of scrimmage" in multiple interviews. Of course, words are wind — and the Panthers ranked 24th and 30th in neutral pace under Canales. They were 22nd in plays last season, dead last the year before, and Young still hasn't finished higher than 35th in yards per attempt. Yet, at least for Week 1, there are extra unknowns in our assumptions, and we are already wrong all the time. If Carolina indeed plays fast against Chicago's pregnable defense, we should get a shootout.

Slow-Paced Slogs

Buffalo Bills at Houston Texans

When **Brandon Beane** served **Sean McDermott** the scapegoat papers and elevated former OC **Joe Brady** to the big chair, not only did he prove you can survive Buffalo winters with thin skin — but hope immediately sprang for the slow-paced, ground-committed offense to spread its wings.

Consider us skeptical. Brady's ascension to OC during the 2023 season marked a significant pivot to the run for Buffalo. His two seasons coordinating Carolina's offense in 2020 and 2021 yielded a 56% neutral pass rate — in the same neighborhood as his 54% rate with the Bills. Buffalo ranked 25th, 25th, and 28th in neutral pace with Brady as OC, and Bills games produced the 24th-, 26th-, and 26th-most combined snaps during that time. Adding **D.J. Moore** and featuring a momentarily healthy **Dalton Kincaid** are arguments for opening the offense back up — but Houston's defense is convincing in the other direction.

The Texans' passing offense only has one direction to go since we last saw **C.J. Stroud** soil himself with 43% completions and four picks in Foxborough. While the team still has faith in Stroud and the addition of **Kayshon Boutte** will, in time, lessen the impact of losing **Jayden Higgins**, the way to attack the Bills begins with handoffs. Buffalo faced the third-highest opponent neutral run rate, and only the Giants surrendered more EPA per play on the ground. Newly imported **David Montgomery** will be busy right out of the gate, and we can expect the Texans to pound the rock as long as game script allows. As short home favorites (-1.5), that should be all day. Houston's games were not particularly voluminous last season, finishing 17th in combined plays. Yet, like the Bills, the Texans were adept at controlling the ball, as both teams finished top three in snaps

differential. Two run-leaning teams playing keepaway is a rancid recipe for play volume.

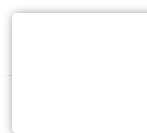
Miami Dolphins at Las Vegas Raiders

Focusing on this matchup's flaccid defenses will tempt us toward the few fantasy-relevant Raiders and Dolphins. They won't find many easier opponents all year. The key is not going overboard, as there's a good chance this one finishes before the other late-window games hit the fourth quarter. The Dolphins might have lost volume-crunching coach **Mike McDaniel**, but they didn't add many accelerants. Miami will keep the ball on the ground with **De'Von Achane** and **Malik Willis** as long as possible — and with a field-goal spread, this should be the rare game where it's possible. Miami's contests produced the fewest combined snaps in the league last year, and it wouldn't be a surprise if they go for the repeat.

If the Dolphins are looking for a spark to speed up this game — and they aren't — the Raiders would not qualify. Currently quarterbacked by the crumbling husk of **Kirk Cousins**, without world-crushing TE **Brock Bowers**, and favored for the last time before Christmas, **Klint Kubiak** won't be itching to air it out in his head coaching debut. His Seahawks had the third-lowest PROE last year and ranked 26th in neutral seconds per snap. Like the Dolphins, the Raiders will run it as long as they can — and there's a solid chance this matchup allows them to longer than in any game this season. Knock yourself out if tickled by the prospect of **Ashton Jeanty** or Achane in a favorable matchup, but keep in mind that stacking slow-paced games is asking a lot from a little.

Atlanta Falcons at Pittsburgh Steelers

After an offseason of reps wasted on **Tua Tagovailoa**'s ghost, the shell-shocked former Dolphin serves as cannon fodder for the Steelers' home opener. **Michael Penix Jr.** will soon take over — not soon enough for



Drake London enthusiasts — but is not ready to avert Atlanta's Week 1 disaster. Tagovailoa can't stretch the field with his arm or brave the pocket long enough to try. With his concussion history, it's hard to blame him — especially with a Pittsburgh pass rush hovering around his helmet. While the jury is still out on **Kevin Stefanski's** preferred pace for the Falcons' offense, it will move better once Penix is firing downfield than with Tua dumping it quicker than Taylor Farms lettuce. Stefanski has faced Pittsburgh 13 times as a head coach, and his offense scored three touchdowns once — six seasons ago. His teams averaged 16.2 points since then.

Pittsburgh's offense almost certainly will not be as tested by the Falcons' defense, even if it has its own challenges. **Aaron Rodgers** inexplicably returns to Pittsburgh, only this time under his old HC from Green Bay. The expectation in some circles is that **Mike McCarthy** will speed the offense up relative to **Mike Tomlin's** final years thanks to a higher pass rate and quicker pace. Rodgers will agree to the passing, but likely won't move appreciably faster. Pittsburgh produced the sixth-fewest plays per game last year, despite the seventh-highest neutral pass rate, because of its 27th-ranked neutral pace. Getting Rodgers to move quicker will probably take more than a McCarthy reunion — and it'll definitely take more than the Tua Falcons.

Update: Tagovailoa was ruled out on Friday, with **Cooper Rush** replacing him as starter. The 32-year-old career backup was signed on the first day of Falcons training camp. This does not meaningfully change the projection for a slow-paced, mostly futile fantasy environment. The line moved two points toward the Steelers (-6), strengthening the chance they control the game with Rodgers' preferred slow pace.

No-Huddle Notes

We will kick off the notes section with our most pertinent pace-based questions. Not everything will become crystal clear after opening week — when does it ever? — but many elusive answers reveal themselves right from the first kickoff.

– Will the offense start out moving faster in Year 2 of **Drake Maye's** partnership with **Josh McDaniels**? The three-time Patriots OC has run up-tempo offenses with multiple quarterbacks, mentioned this offseason that they are looking for the next level in his scheme, and Maye practiced hurrying to the line with no play calls throughout the offseason. Seattle is a daunting spot to debut offensive wrinkles, so if we see signs of speeding up in the opener, it should mean wheels up for the year.

– Thursday night's harebrained Australia game at least offers an early glimpse of two tempo trends. Will we be correct in projecting the **Rams to speed back up** with **Kliff Kingsbury** on staff and turbocharge their tight end rotation via increased no-huddle usage? On the other end, the 49ers uncharacteristically played faster and threw a lot more than we'd gotten used to. Their games were significantly more voluminous as a result, but much of it was due to upside-down game scripts and **Mac Jones** starting. With **Brock Purdy** in, the pace plummeted to league-low levels. The early peek at both offenses could confirm expectations.

– We know the Commanders will be slower with **David Blough** replacing Kingsbury, but we don't know how much slower. The bet is a more deliberate approach involving far more huddles and under-center snaps won't completely crush Washington's tempo. A visit with the Eagles' defense serves up a daunting first test of that theory.

– Will projected improvement from the Bengals' defense and far more under-center plays for the offense appreciably affect Cincinnati's annually pass-drunk approach? They were 29th in defensive EPA per play and

second in shotgun rate a year ago (82%). If the run game is more efficient with fewer snaps in shotgun — from which teams tend to pass more — and the defense keeps the Bengals in more positive scripts, their main pace catalyst could be threatened. Cincinnati does not operate quickly between snaps, and less shotgun won't help there, so aggressive pass rates are non-negotiable from a play-volume perspective.

– Will Jets-Titans be our first “beautifully ugly” game of the season? If the main slate did not feature a meaty 12 games, we might have shoehorned this one into *Up in Pace*. The Jets' offense, while unlikely to be fast-paced, has several exciting elements aside from their play-caller. The Titans should eventually skew toward the quicker-moving teams under OC **Brian Daboll** after many years of plodding — although growing pains are expected. With both the Jets and Titans deploying combustible secondaries ranked 29th and 30th by PFF, respectively, after allowing the most and fourth-most EPA per pass play a year ago, at least these offenses get a soft opener.

– It may be tough to tell until we see the Cowboys face a significant test — and starting with the Giants and Commanders probably won't qualify — but there is a scary path to Dallas games not offering as much volume as expected. The Cowboys will be improved on defense, as they made significant roster and coaching upgrades; and, really, they can't get any worse. Importing **Christian Parker** as DC might be enough, by itself, to slow Cowboys games down.

Parker's defense is **rooted in Vic Fangio's coverage schemes**. Fangio defenses force opposing offenses to dink-and-dunk their way down the field, grinding clock and slowing games. Before he landed in Philadelphia as DC, the Eagles allowed the fifth-highest explosive play rate. In two seasons since, they've surrendered big plays at the lowest and sixth-lowest clips.

Over the last 10 years, Fangio's teams were consistently involved in low-volume games. Ignoring the COVID, fan-less, record-scoring season of

2020, Fangio was a DC eight times (he was a consultant for the Eagles the 10th year, when they allowed the second-lowest explosive play rate). The average combined offensive plays in games with Fangio as DC — across four different organizations — ranked 32nd, 31st, 30th, 30th, 25th, 18th, 16th, and 14th.

Cowboys contests have finished top five in combined snaps six of the last seven years, usually helped by their Duraflame log of a secondary. Dallas gave up the second- and seventh-highest explosive play rates over the last two seasons and almost certainly will allow a lower frequency of pace-juicing chunk gains under Parker. Fortunately, the Cowboys are still piloted by **Dak Prescott** and the offense remains fast. Yet, it is worrisome from a pace perspective if the offense will no longer chase game scripts while getting quickly thrown back on the field due to a demolished defense.

– Week 1 wraps with our first glimpse of **Davis Webb** calling plays for the Broncos. We have heard nothing but pace-positive projections of faster play-calling and a streamlined between-snaps operation. While that remains to be seen, Denver had already sped up under **Sean Payton** and **Bo Nix**. There isn't a ton of room to grow from a play-volume angle, as the Broncos ranked fifth in snaps and their games were second in combined plays — but we'd love to see them try.

Dan Campbell, Detroit Lions, In-Season Package, Snaps & Pace



SUBSCRIPTIONS

NFL Products

NBA Products

Golf Products

The Solver

ARTICLES

NFL Content Schedule

Silva's Matchups

Best Ball

Free Podcasts

DFS

Projections

Strategy

DFS Optimizer

Simulations

ETR TEAM

About

YouTube

Discord

Twitter

Gambling problem? Call 1-800-GAMBLER (NJ/PA/IL), 1-800-9-WITH-IT (IN only), 1-800-BETS-OFF (IA only), 1-800-522-4700 (CO Only), TN REDLINE: 800-889-9789 or 1-888-532-3500 (VA only).

